

Dessert Cups

A grab-and-go layered dessert-cup bar — clear cups built to order with cream, cake/cookie layers, sauce drizzle, a slice on top, and a dusting of matcha or cocoa. A row of flavors (matcha, tiramisu, berry cheesecake, chocolate) that's as much content as it is product. Low startup, very high margin.

The Insight

Dessert cups sell on looks. A clear cup turns layers into a vertical, photogenic flex, every flavor is a different color, and the lineup shot *is* the marketing. It's one of the lowest-barrier food businesses there is — no oven required for the assembly, cheap ingredients, made-to-order in minutes, and it rides the booming grab-and-go dessert wave. Tiramisu alone is an \$850M market growing ~5%/yr, and no one owns the branded "dessert cup" lineup in most US towns.

The Product

A 12–16oz clear cup, layered: cream/mousse base → cake or cookie crumble → sauce drizzle (matcha, caramel/coffee, berry, chocolate) → a square slice on top (tiramisu, cheesecake, matcha cake) → dust of matcha/cocoa. A **flight of 4 signature flavors** as the hero, plus seasonal/limited drops. Grab-and-go with a dome lid + spoon.

US Market & Competitors

- **Tiramisu market \$850M (2025), +5%/yr**; grab-and-go dessert + single-serve cups is one of the hottest segments; "edible cup" formats are an emerging viral wedge.
- **Competitors:** açai/yogurt bars, cake-by-the-slice cafes, regional dessert-cup shops — **fragmented, no dominant US "dessert cup" brand.**
- **Buyers:** dessert/impulse shoppers, mall & food-court traffic, students, late-night crowd, events, and DTC/local delivery.
- **Edge:** the most photogenic item in any case + the lowest skill floor to produce; the flavor lineup is a built-in content engine.

China Import Sourcing (the cheap inputs)

- **Custom-printed clear PET cups + dome lids + spoons:** Alibaba bulk from ~\$12–\$39 per 1,000 cups (MOQ ~1,000), custom branding included → your branded cup is nearly-free advertising in every customer's hand.
- **Display fridge, piping tools, squeeze bottles, sealing machine** (for grab-and-go/delivery) all sourceable direct at a fraction of US restaurant-supply prices. Add ~20–35% over FOB for freight + duty.
- **Ingredients** (cream, mascarpone, cookies, matcha) sourced locally for freshness.

Startup Cost & Unit Economics

- **Cottage/market start: under \$500** — cups, ingredients, squeeze bottles, a cooler. Kiosk/cart: \$10,000–\$40,000 (display fridge, branding, permits).
- **Per cup:** ingredients \$1.00–\$1.75 + cup/lid/spoon \$0.10–\$0.20. **COGS ≈ \$1.25–\$2.00.**
- **Price: \$6–\$9 each**, \$24–\$32 four-flavor flights. **Gross margin 75–85%.**

Revenue Potential

A single kiosk doing 80–150 cups/day at ~\$7 = **\$560–\$1,050/day**, ~\$1.75 COGS. Spikes with events and seasons. Scales via multiple kiosks, wholesale to cafes, DTC/delivery (sealed cups), and a content-led brand. The flight format raises average order value.

Go-To-Market

1. **Content-first:** film the layered build + the 4-flavor lineup top-down (this exact format goes viral).
2. **Plant where the traffic is:** mall food court, high-foot-traffic strip, campus, markets.
3. **Lead with the flight:** push the 4-flavor sampler for higher AOV and more content.
4. **Branded cup = walking ad;** seasonal/limited flavors keep the feed fresh.

30 / 60 / 90-Day Launch

- **30:** finalize 4 signature recipes + a flight; order branded cups; test at markets/events; film everything.
- **60:** lock a kiosk/cart or cafe wholesale pilot; permits; build the content engine to 10k+ followers off the lineup.
- **90:** open the kiosk; add seasonal drops + delivery (sealed cups); line up location #2 or a wholesale account.

Risks

- **Cold chain / freshness** → refrigerated display, make-to-order or short pars, sell fast.
- **Labor at rush** → pre-build components (creams, crumbles, sauces) for fast assembly.
- **Permits** → start cottage-food/markets, move to commercial kitchen + kiosk to scale (dairy rules vary by state).
- **Copcats** → win on brand, flavor lineup, and content, not recipe secrecy.